

By consciously observing your moods when you spend money, you may discover a pattern. If, for example, you find that you tend to spend money when you are depressed, you may want to avoid a shopping mall at all costs when feeling this way. By substituting the activity of shopping with another less destructive activity like exercise, you may succeed in reducing your spending compulsions during times of depression.

Ben became so used to his father's extravagance that he began to take advantage of it. Soon, Charles found his generosity had extended to Ben's friends and their demands. One weekend, Charles found himself paying for everyone when he brought Ben and his friends to the amusement park. This was not necessary since the parents had given their children more than enough money to cover the day's events. Ben's friends thought this was great because they were able to pocket their parents' money. Since Charles never complained, and in fact encouraged this behavior, he found his weekends becoming increasingly costly.

Before he knew it, Charles had excessive credit card debt. Instead of curtailing his spending (which to him wasn't an option), it continued to spiral out of control until he was forced to stop. One night he took his children to an expensive restaurant and all three of his credit cards were declined. Not understanding why this happened, Ben asked his dad what the problem was. Charles finally broke down and admitted his financial problems.

To his amazement, Ben and Virginia started suggesting things they could do that didn't cost money. They said, "Dad it's not important what we do, just that we do it with you." They even admitted that they felt they were always rushing around during their weekends with their father. In trying to give them so much, Charles succeeded in giving them *too* much.

The sudden realization that he didn't have to buy their

